

Lecture 20: SQL Introduction (DDL)

Tables, Constraints, and Schema Evolution

Z2004: Database Management Systems



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Lecture Outline

What you should be able to do after this lecture

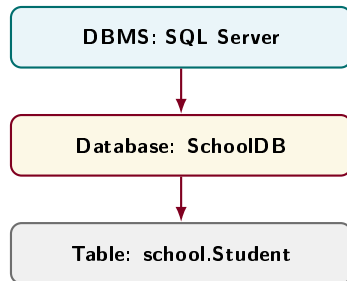
- ➊ Explain SQL **sublanguages** (DDL/DML/DCL/TCL) and choose correct **data types** in SQL Server.
- ➋ Use **SSMS** to connect, run scripts, and interpret error messages.
- ➌ Create a **database**, optionally create a **schema**, and create **tables**.
- ➍ Enforce correctness using **constraints**: PRIMARY KEY, FOREIGN KEY, UNIQUE, NOT NULL, CHECK, DEFAULT.
- ➎ Modify schema with ALTER TABLE and understand DROP vs TRUNCATE vs DELETE.

Tooling: Microsoft SQL Server + **SQL Server Management Studio (SSMS)**.

DBMS vs Database vs Table

- ▶ **DBMS**: the software (SQL Server) that stores data and runs SQL.
- ▶ **Database**: a container managed by the DBMS (e.g., SchoolDB).
- ▶ **Table**: a structure inside a database that stores rows and columns.
- ▶ **Row**: one record (one student).
- ▶ **Column**: one attribute (Name, Dept, GPA).

In this lecture: we learn how to **define** these structures using **DDL**.



Relational vocabulary

Math term	SQL term
Relation	Table
Tuple	Row
Attribute	Column
Domain	Allowed values (type/constraint)

The goal of DDL is to define the **domain** correctly using **data types + constraints**.

Example domain rules:

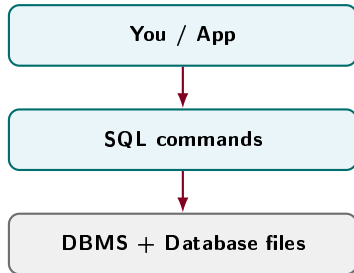
- ▶ GPA must be between 0 and 4.
- ▶ Dept code must be exactly 5 characters.
- ▶ Every student must have a name (NOT NULL).

SQL: Why it exists

SQL is the standard language used to **talk to a relational DBMS**.

What SQL gives you:

- ▶ A **declarative** way to define data structures and ask questions.
- ▶ **Constraints** to keep data correct.
- ▶ A consistent language across many systems (SQL Server, PostgreSQL, MySQL, ...).



SQL: A brief histor

- ▶ 1970: Codd proposes the **relational model**.
- ▶ 1974: IBM develops **SEQUEL** (early SQL).
- ▶ 1986: SQL becomes an **ANSI standard**; later ISO.
- ▶ Today: SQL remains the industry default for relational data.

1970

Relational model (E. F. Codd)

1974

SEQUEL/SQL prototype at IBM

1986

ANSI SQL standard

Now

SQL in SQL Server, PostgreSQL, MySQL, Oracle, cloud warehouses

SQL is a family of commands

- ▶ **DDL (Data Definition Language)**: define structure
 - CREATE, ALTER, DROP, TRUNCATE
- ▶ **DML (Data Manipulation Language)**: work with rows
 - SELECT, INSERT, UPDATE, DELETE
- ▶ **DCL (Data Control Language)**: permissions
 - GRANT, REVOKE
- ▶ **TCL (Transaction Control Language)**: transactions
 - BEGIN TRAN, COMMIT, ROLLBACK

In this lecture (L20), we focus on **DDL**: building the database structure correctly so DML works smoothly later.

SQL Server data types: what they mean

Category	Type	Use it for (example)
Integers	INT	counts/IDs: Age=21, SID=1005
Exact decimals	DECIMAL(5,2)	money/grades: GPA=3.75, Price=49.99
Approx decimals	FLOAT	scientific values: temperature=36.6123
Text (ASCII)	VARCHAR(50)	emails, codes (English-only)
Text (Unicode)	NVARCHAR(50)	names with accents/Arabic/Swahili
Fixed text	CHAR(5)	fixed-size codes: 'DB101'
Dates	DATE	'2026-04-16'
Date+time	DATETIME2	'2026-04-16 09:30:00'
Boolean-ish	BIT	IsActive=1

Important: use DECIMAL (not FLOAT) for money/grades to avoid rounding errors.

Strings: CHAR vs VARCHAR vs NVARCHAR

CHAR(n) (fixed length)

- ▶ Always stores exactly n characters (pads with spaces).
- ▶ Use for truly fixed codes (e.g., 'TZ', 'DB101').

VARCHAR(n) (variable length, non-Unicode)

- ▶ Stores up to n characters; uses only what you need.
- ▶ OK if you are sure text is only English/ASCII.

NVARCHAR(n) (variable length, Unicode)

- ▶ Supports multilingual text (recommended for names).
- ▶ Typically uses more storage than VARCHAR.

```
-- Compare storage behaviour
DECLARE @a CHAR(5)      = 'DB1';
DECLARE @b VARCHAR(5)   = 'DB1';
DECLARE @c NVARCHAR(5)  = N'Znz';

-- CHAR(5) stores 'DB1 '
-- VARCHAR stores 'DB1'
```

UG default: use NVARCHAR for names/text unless you have a strong reason not to.

NULL is not 0 and not an empty string

NULL means: *unknown / missing / not provided.*

- ▶ NULL is **not equal** to anything (even another NULL).
- ▶ This is why SQL uses `IS NULL` and `IS NOT NULL`.
- ▶ Empty string `''` is a real value (a known, empty text).

Why it matters in DDL:

- ▶ NOT NULL forbids missing values.
- ▶ CHECK constraints must handle NULL correctly.

-- NULL comparisons

```
SELECT CASE WHEN NULL = NULL  
  THEN 'equal' ELSE 'not equal'  
  END;
```

-- Correct way

```
SELECT CASE WHEN NULL IS NULL  
  THEN 'is null' ELSE 'not null'  
  END;
```

-- Empty string is different

```
SELECT CASE WHEN '' = ''  
  THEN 'equal' ELSE 'not equal'  
  END;
```

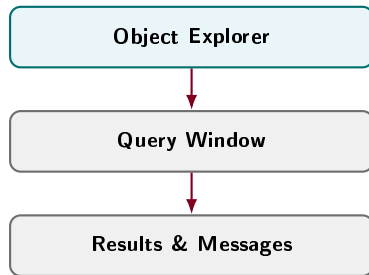
SSMS: What you need to know

Main panes

- ▶ **Object Explorer:** databases, tables, columns (refresh often).
- ▶ **Query Window:** where you write SQL.
- ▶ **Results + Messages:** output tables and error messages.

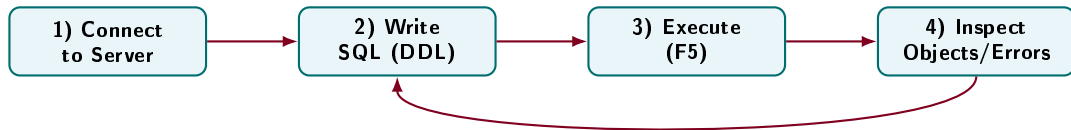
How to debug

- ▶ Read the **first error** in the *Messages* tab.
- ▶ Fix one error, run again.
- ▶ Always confirm the current database: `SELECT DB_NAME();`



SSMS: The Workflow

You will do the same loop again and again:



Tip: if a command fails, read the **exact error line** and fix one issue at a time.

SSMS: Your First Commands

In SSMS, open **New Query** and run:

```
-- What server am I connected to?  
SELECT @@SERVERNAME AS ServerName;  
  
-- Which database am I currently using?  
SELECT DB_NAME() AS CurrentDB;
```

If your current database isn't what you want, use `USE <dbName>;` (shown next).

Writing a clean SQL script in SSMS

Good scripts are easy to re-run and easy to read.

```
-- 1) Always start by checking where you are
SELECT DB_NAME() AS CurrentDB;

-- 2) Switch to the correct DB before creating tables
USE SchoolDB;

-- 3) Use comments to separate tasks
-- === Create tables ===
-- === Add constraints ===
```

Note: SQL Server also supports GO as a batch separator in SSMS, but we keep scripts beginner-simple and avoid it unless needed.

Naming conventions (so your DB stays readable)

Tables/columns

- ▶ Tables: singular nouns: `Student`, `Course`, `Enrolment`
- ▶ Primary keys: `StudentID` or `SID` (be consistent)
- ▶ Foreign keys: same name as referenced PK (e.g., `SID` in `Enrolment`)

Constraints

- ▶ `PK_Student`, `FK_Enrolment_Student`, `UQ_Student_Email`,
`CHK_Student_GPA`

Why it matters:

- ▶ Easier debugging (error messages show constraint names).
- ▶ Easier teamwork (everyone understands object purpose).

Step 1: Create a Database (SSMS)

A **database** is a container for tables, views, procedures, and security.

```
-- Create a new database
CREATE DATABASE SchoolDB;

-- Switch into it
USE SchoolDB;
```

In SSMS: Object Explorer → Databases → (Refresh) to see SchoolDB.

Step 2: Schemas (dbo vs custom)

A **schema** is a namespace inside a database. Most beginner scripts use `dbo`.

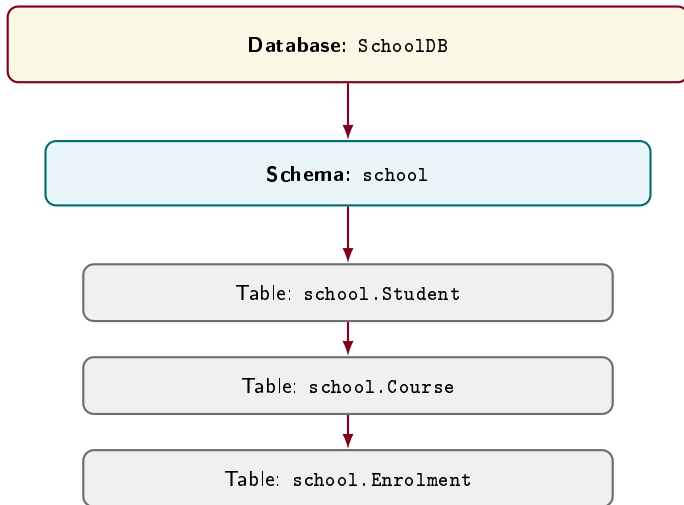
```
-- Create a schema for the course
CREATE SCHEMA school;

-- A table name is: schema.table
-- Example: school.Student
```

Why schemas?

- ▶ Organize objects (`school.*`, `hr.*`, `sales.*`).
- ▶ Control permissions at schema level.
- ▶ Avoid name clashes.

Where do tables live?



Design Rule: Start from the ER Idea

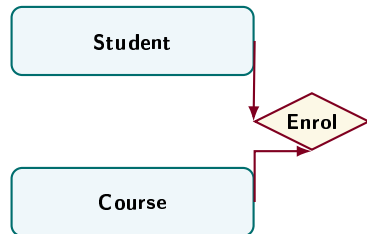
Before writing `CREATE TABLE`, answer:

Entities (tables)

- ▶ Student
- ▶ Course
- ▶ Enrolment (relationship between Student and Course)

Keys

- ▶ Student: SID (primary key)
- ▶ Course: CID (primary key)
- ▶ Enrolment: (SID, CID) (composite primary key)



Data Types: The Practical Shortlist

For this course, you can cover 90% of cases with:

- ▶ Integers: `INT`, `BIGINT`
- ▶ Text: `VARCHAR(n)` (ASCII), `NVARCHAR(n)` (Unicode)
- ▶ Money/grades: `DECIMAL(p,s)` (exact)
- ▶ Dates: `DATE`, `DATETIME2`
- ▶ Flags: `BIT`
- ▶ IDs: `IDENTITY(1,1)` (auto-number)

Common mistake: using `FLOAT` for money/marks (rounding errors).

Constraints: your data guardrails

Constraints stop bad data *at the door*.

- ▶ **PRIMARY KEY**: unique row ID (and NOT NULL).
- ▶ **FOREIGN KEY**: must match a key in another table.
- ▶ **UNIQUE**: no duplicates (e.g., Email).
- ▶ **NOT NULL**: value is required.
- ▶ **CHECK**: rule like GPA range.
- ▶ **DEFAULT**: value if user doesn't provide one.

Typical examples:

- ▶ GPA: CHECK (GPA BETWEEN 0 AND 4)
- ▶ Credits: DEFAULT 3
- ▶ Email: UNIQUE

Key idea: constraints are part of the **schema** (DDL), not part of the data (DML).

Natural key vs surrogate key

Natural key (meaningful)

- ▶ Example: CID='DB101'
- ▶ Pros: readable, already exists
- ▶ Cons: can change; may be long

Surrogate key (artificial)

- ▶ Example: SID INT IDENTITY(1,1)
- ▶ Pros: small, stable, fast joins
- ▶ Cons: needs an extra UNIQUE constraint for natural values (like Email)

Surrogate key example

Student

SID = 1, 2, 3, ...

Name = 'Asha'

Email = 'a@uni.ac.tz'

Create Table 1: Student

```
USE SchoolDB;

CREATE TABLE school.Student (
    SID          INT IDENTITY(1,1) NOT NULL,
    Name         NVARCHAR(100)     NOT NULL,
    Dept         CHAR(5)           NOT NULL,
    GPA          DECIMAL(3,2)       NULL,
    DateJoined   DATE              NOT NULL DEFAULT (CAST(GETDATE() AS DATE)),

    CONSTRAINT PK_Student PRIMARY KEY (SID),
    CONSTRAINT CHK_Student_GPA CHECK (GPA IS NULL OR (GPA BETWEEN 0.00 AND
        4.00))
);
```

Read it top-to-bottom: columns first, then constraints.

Create Table 2: Course

```
CREATE TABLE school.Course (  
    CID      CHAR(5)          NOT NULL ,  
    CName    NVARCHAR(200)    NOT NULL ,  
    Credits  SMALLINT         NOT NULL DEFAULT (3),  
  
    CONSTRAINT PK_Course PRIMARY KEY (CID),  
    CONSTRAINT CHK_Course_Credits CHECK (Credits IN (1,2,3,4))  
);
```

We used a natural key for Course (e.g., DB101). That's fine when codes are stable.

Create Table 3: Enrolment (junction table)

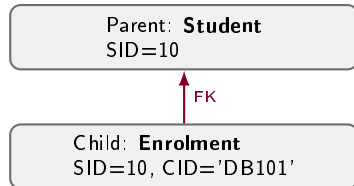
```
CREATE TABLE school.Enrolment (  
    SID      INT      NOT NULL,  
    CID      CHAR(5)  NOT NULL,  
    Grade    CHAR(2)  NULL,  
  
    CONSTRAINT PK_Enrolment PRIMARY KEY (SID, CID),  
    CONSTRAINT FK_Enrolment_Student FOREIGN KEY (SID)  
        REFERENCES school.Student(SID)  
        ON DELETE CASCADE,  
    CONSTRAINT FK_Enrolment_Course FOREIGN KEY (CID)  
        REFERENCES school.Course(CID)  
        ON DELETE CASCADE,  
    CONSTRAINT CHK_Enrolment_Grade CHECK (Grade IN ('A','B','C','D','F') OR  
        Grade IS NULL)  
);
```

Foreign keys: delete/update actions

A foreign key can define what happens when the parent row changes.

- ▶ **ON DELETE CASCADE**: delete child rows automatically.
- ▶ **ON DELETE NO ACTION**: block delete if children exist (safe default).
- ▶ **ON UPDATE NO ACTION**: block updating a referenced key (common).

UG rule of thumb: use **NO ACTION** unless you are very sure you want automatic deletion.



Quick note: keys and indexes

- ▶ In SQL Server, **PRIMARY KEY** and **UNIQUE** usually create an **index** automatically.
- ▶ Indexes make lookups and joins faster, but they add overhead to inserts/updates.
- ▶ We'll study indexes properly later (B-trees, query optimization).

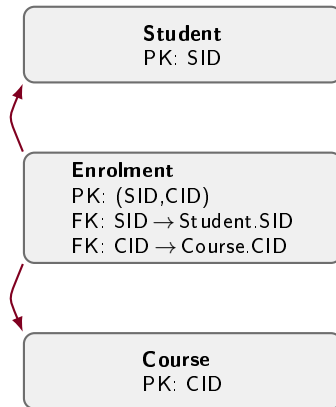
Keys & Constraints

Primary key (PK): uniquely identifies a row.

- ▶ Cannot be NULL.
- ▶ Can be **single-column** or **composite**.

Foreign key (FK): enforces a valid reference to another table.

- ▶ Prevents orphan rows.
- ▶ Can cascade deletes/updates (use carefully).



ALTER (DDL): definition & basic syntax

ALTER is a Data Definition Language (DDL) command used to **modify the structure** of an existing database object (most commonly a table) **without deleting it**.

Common ALTER TABLE operations:

- ▶ **ADD column** (append a new column)
- ▶ **DROP COLUMN** (remove a column + its data)
- ▶ **ALTER/MODIFY COLUMN** (change type/size/NULLability)
- ▶ **ADD/DROP constraint** (PK/FK/UNIQUE/CHECK/DEFAULT)

```
-- Add a column
ALTER TABLE table_name
ADD column_name datatype;

-- Drop a column
ALTER TABLE table_name
DROP COLUMN column_name;

-- Change a column (SQL Server)
ALTER TABLE table_name
ALTER COLUMN column_name datatype;

-- Add a constraint (example)
ALTER TABLE table_name
ADD CONSTRAINT UQ_Name
UNIQUE (column_name);
```

ALTER TABLE: Typical changes

```
-- Add a new column
ALTER TABLE Student
    ADD Email NVARCHAR(255) NULL;

-- Make Email unique (no duplicates)
ALTER TABLE Student
    ADD CONSTRAINT UQ_Student_Email UNIQUE (Email);

-- Change a column's definition
ALTER TABLE Student
    ALTER COLUMN Name NVARCHAR(150) NOT NULL;
```

Rule: if a column already contains NULLs, you must clean data first before switching to NOT NULL.

DROP vs TRUNCATE vs DELETE (one slide you must memorize)

```
-- Remove the table object
DROP TABLE Enrolment;

-- Remove all rows, keep the table
TRUNCATE TABLE Student;

-- Remove some rows (with filter)
DELETE FROM Student
WHERE Dept = 'CSE';
```

	DROP	TRUNCATE	DELETE
Removes rows	✓	✓	✓
Keeps table	×	✓	✓
WHERE allowed	×	×	✓
Typical speed	Fast	Very fast	Slower

Safety tip: never run DROP/TRUNCATE in the wrong database. Always confirm `SELECT DB_NAME();`.

Mini lab: prove your schema works

After creating the tables, insert a few rows and test the FK.

```
USE SchoolDB;

-- Insert a student
INSERT INTO Student (Name, Dept, GPA)
VALUES (N'Asha Ali', 'CSE ', 3.80);

-- Insert a course
INSERT INTO Course (CID, CName, Credits)
VALUES ('DB101', N'Introduction to Databases', 3);

-- Enrol the student (must succeed if FK is correct)
INSERT INTO Enrolment (SID, CID, Grade)
VALUES (1, 'DB101', NULL);

-- Check what we have
SELECT * FROM Student;
SELECT * FROM Enrolment;
```

Key Takeaways

- ✓ In **SSMS**, the loop is: connect → write SQL → run → inspect objects/errors.
- ✓ DDL builds the structure: `CREATE DATABASE`, `CREATE SCHEMA`, `CREATE TABLE`.
- ✓ Correctness comes from **constraints** (PK/FK/UNIQUE/NOT NULL/CHECK/DEFAULT).
- ✓ Relationships are enforced with **foreign keys** (and a junction table for many-to-many).
- ✓ `ALTER` evolves safely; `DROP/TRUNCATE` are powerful and dangerous.

Next lecture: SQL DML — `SELECT`, `WHERE`, `ORDER BY`.